cannot proceed with two public interest litigation (PIL) petitions filed against Soren for alleged money-laundering, the reprieve freed him only from judicial scrutiny—the ED can still probe the allegations against him. Legal experts believe the CM will eventually have to appear before the central agency as no court will intervene in the investigation process.

Soren has been battling legal challenges on multiple fronts since February when the BJP approached Governor Bais demanding the CM's disqualification for getting a mining contract, which he had acquired earlier, renewed while in office in 2021. Following a political uproar, he surrendered the mining lease (in Angara block of Ranchi district) in February, but that didn't stop the governor from forwarding the complaint to the EC the next month. The poll body, it is learnt, made its recommendations in August, but Bais has been sitting over the EC's advice, letting uncertainty prevail over the state government. Buzz about the EC recommending Soren's disqualification led to panic in the ruling alliance and 32 legislators were moved briefly to Congress-ruled Chhattisgarh to pre-empt alleged poaching attempts. Soren, however, soon brought them back and won a confidence motion on September 5 with 48 votes in the 81-member assembly amid a walkout by the BJP and its allies.

Since then, Soren has taken a slew of popular decisions, including relaunching the 'Sarkar Aapke Dwar' initiative that provides government services to beneficiaries at their doorstep in more than 4,300 panchayats. The CM has also been visiting some of these panchayats. However, with more than two years left in his current tenure, Soren continues to be on a sticky wicket. His disqualification is still a possibility and he cannot dodge the ED summons forever, but it's clear he won't go down without a fight. ■



TO PROSPERITY
PM Narendra Modi at the unveiling of the Kempegowda statue in Bengaluru, Nov. 11

KARNATAKA

COURTING THE VOKKALIGAS

By Ajay Sukumaran

The bid to honour a prominent medieval figure and its likely impact on politics has become a subject of controversy in Karnataka. In the run-up to the November 11 event where Prime Minister Narendra Modi unveiled the 108-feet-tall bronze statue of Kempegowda, the 16th century founder of Bengaluru, state BJP leaders had fanned out to several historical sites to bring back 'sacred mud' for the ceremony. Behind the symbolism lay another motive—in southern Karnataka, where it has little presence, the BJP is making a sustained bid to woo the Vokkaliga community, whose historical icon Kempegowda is. A row soon ensued, with the Janata Dal (Secular)—the main beneficiary of Vokkaliga votes—accusing the BJP of trying to appropriate Kempegowda for politics, especially as the invite for the event excluded JD(S) supremo H.D. Deve Gowda, the tallest leader of the Vokkaliga community.

THE VOKKALIGA HEARTLAND IN SOUTH KARNATAKA HAS HELD OUT AS THE BJP'S WEAK SPOT

The BJP has long eyed seven-eight districts in the Vokkaliga